Venezuela: Talking Points (Grades 5-6)

Video: about 8 minutes. Simple words.

Words to know

- Independence: a country rules itself.
- Dictator: a leader with all the power, chosen without a fair vote.
- Democracy: people vote to choose their leaders.
- Socialism: the government controls much of the money and businesses.
- Inflation: prices go up fast.
- Emancipation: setting people free.

The story

- Long ago: Indigenous people lived here. Columbus came in 1498. Spain ruled, and Caracas was founded in 1567. Venezuela may mean "Little Venice."
- Simón Bolívar, "El Libertador," led the fight for independence from Spain. The Battle of Carabobo in 1821 freed Venezuela.
- 1854: a law signed by President José Gregorio Monagas ended slavery.
- Indigenous, African and European people mixed their food, music and ideas: arepas, joropo, Spanish.
- Angel Falls is the tallest waterfall in the world. Venezuela has more oil than any other country.
- 1958: the last dictator left and democracy began.
- Golden age (1958 to 1983): oil money, big cities, free music lessons (El Sistema), baseball stars.
- From 1999, Hugo Chávez and later Nicolás Maduro: socialism, close friendship with Fidel Castro of Cuba, high prices, little food and medicine.
- How rights were taken away, step by step (UN and human rights groups): unfair courts, a TV channel shut down, no limit on staying in power, food used to reward supporters, protesters arrested.
- Nearly 8 million people left Venezuela. Many went to Colombia, Peru, Brazil, Chile and the U.S. (Florida). Families were split up.
- January 2026: the U.S. captured Maduro; a court in New York will decide his case. María Corina Machado won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2025 and came home on October 25, 2026.
- Elections are expected in 2027, but the date is not set yet.

Questions to ask

- What would you pack if you had to move to a new country?
- Why is voting important?
- What foods and music does your family share?

Sources: Reuters, AP, UNHCR, U.S. EIA, UN Fact-Finding Mission, Human Rights Watch. Prepared Oct 28, 2026.